

The Language of Transition: New and Sustainable Meanings [B2]

Il nostro approccio nei confronti dei problemi legati al cambiamento climatico è molto cambiato negli ultimi anni. Nel tentativo di costruire società più responsabili, anche la lingua ha subito forti trasformazioni.

Major world events always change the language we use. The digital revolution provided many new words related to technology. In the near future, confronting the challenges of climate change marks a huge transformation in our societies, as we transition from fossil fuels to renewable energies. Meanwhile, social or cultural transition looks forward to more open and fairer societies. In all cases, while various forces of transition are under way, a flood of new terminology accompanies them.

SIMPLY SUSTAINABLE

‘Sustainable’ is an adjective that originally meant “[something] that can be maintained at a certain rate or level”. Nowadays, we associate the word with the environment and sustainable development, meaning economic or industrial development that does not deplete natural resources. Similarly, in the past a person described as ‘green’ was considered ‘ingenuous’ and ‘easy to manipulate’; but we’re all happy to be called ‘green’ these days! To be ‘green’ is to be ecological and sensitive to the environment. We now have the verb ‘to green’, meaning to make something more environmentally-friendly, and we know that green walls and green roofs are not covered in green paint, but rather in plants that absorb carbon and reduce the temperature of buildings. To whitewash literally means to give a wall a quick coat of white paint to cover up the dirt or cracks underneath. Nowadays, the term whitewashing is commonly used as a metaphor for concealing immoral or illegal activity. More recently we’ve started talking about ‘greenwashing’: this means making something seem more environmentally-friendly while continuing with old polluting practices.

'DE' OR 'POST'?

Many new terms actually originate in other languages but pass into English when they are used internationally. In 2004, French economist Serge Latouche came up with the idea of 'décroissance'. Nearly twenty years later, the English translation, 'degrowth', is more familiar in public debate on the world stage. In both languages, the prefix 'de-' gives a sense of 'undoing' and the concept of degrowth refers to a downscaling, or shrinking, of production and consumption, leaving greater space for ecological and human well-being. However, the term has been criticised for sounding too negative. "What's not to like about growth?" people ask. In 2006 the German economist Niko Paech introduced the term 'Postwachstumsökonomie', translated into English as 'post-growth economy'. In contrast to 'degrowth', 'post-growth' is often seen as a more positive approach, encapsulating a multitude of possible futures where human potential and happiness can be enhanced all over the world. Opinions differ over the concept of 'deglobalisation'. For some, it means concentrating on local producers and logistics to avoid the costly and damaging transportation of goods around the globe, and the relocation of factories to poorer countries. For others, it signifies a less-connected world, fewer treaties and agreements, and therefore less cooperation between nations with an increase in protectionist policies.

RE-DOING THINGS

You may be familiar with the Rs of waste management: refuse, reduce, reuse, repurpose and finally, recycle — all form part of what is called the circular economy and are aimed at limiting the production of waste that needs to be burned or placed in landfill sites in favour of sustainable practices. In recent years we have added the term 'regenerative', as in 'regenerative agriculture', which seeks to rehabilitate and conserve the soil in harmony with nature. There is also 'rewilding', where land is restored to its natural uncultivated state and species that have been driven out or exterminated are reintroduced.

DIFFERENT OR DIVERSE?

Should we say 'different' or 'diverse'? 'Difference' suggests [otherness](#), while 'diversity' is usually defined as the presence of difference in our new, pro-social world. It refers to the inclusion of different races, genders, ethnicities and [abilities](#) in social, cultural and political life. But [beware!](#) All too often, when national or local governments talk about '[reaching out](#) to diverse communities', they use the word as a blanket term, without specifying who exactly they are trying to give a voice to and why. This can become part of 'social washing', similar to greenwashing, where there is a large discrepancy between perceived commitments to social issues and concrete action.

NOT THE SAME

Speaking of differences and similarities, '[equity](#)' and '[equality](#)', two terms that are very much in vogue today, are frequently used interchangeably — but they're not the same. 'Equality' means that the same benefits are distributed to all and everyone is treated in the same way, independently of their needs. On the other hand, '[equity](#)' appeals to a much more abstract concept of fairness. It recognises the fact that not all people start from the same point, and that systemic barriers and privileges mean that not everyone can 'come to the table', or participate in a negotiation, with the same power and resources. Equitable projects provide structures and processes to correct these imbalances.

NO QUICK FIX

This is why, the next time you hear a politician talking confidently about African countries [leapfrogging](#) over the mistakes of the western industrial model and going straight towards a green economy, you should be sceptical! 'Leapfrog' is the English name for the traditional game in which children energetically jump over a companion who [bends down](#) in front of them. In real life there is no '[level playing field](#)' — a situation in which everyone has a fair and equal chance of success. Without the infrastructure, the technology,

the knowledge, skills and finance that exist in developed countries, it will be extremely difficult for developing nations to make that leap.

Glossary

- **rate** = ritmo
- **whitewashing** = insabbiamento
- **undoing** = disfare
- **beware!** = attenzione!
- **roofs** = tetti
- **equity** = equità
- **dirt** = sporco, sporcizia
- **equality** = uguaglianza
- **leapfrogging** = saltare le tappe
- **level playing field** = parità di condizioni
- **shrinking** = ridurre
- **repurpose** = riconvertire
- **treaties** = trattati
- **restored** = ripristinare, restaurare
- **reaching out** = avvicinarsi
- **bends down** = chinarsi
- **fairer** = più giuste
- **deplete** = esaurire
- **whitewash** = imbiancare
- **coat** = strato
- **concealing** = occultare
- **landfill sites** = discariche
- **driven out** = espellere, allontanare
- **are under way** = essere in corso
- **flood** = ondata (lett. inondazione)
- **avoid** = evitare
- **seeks** = cercare di
- **soil** = suolo, terra
- **sensitive** = sensibile
- **well-being** = benessere
- **waste management** = gestione dei rifiuti
- **aimed at** = avere come obiettivo
- **otherness** = alterità

- **abilities** = capacità